THE NUTCRACKER STORY

Meet the ballet · the story in six scenes

READ

Story summary

The composer Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky (1840–1893) was a Russian composer. He also wrote the ballets *Swan Lake* and *The Sleeping Beauty*.

The ballet The Nutcracker was first performed on December 18, 1892, at the Mariinsky Theatre in St. Petersburg, Russia. The choreography was by Lev Ivanov, from plans by Marius Petipa.

The story It comes from a tale by E. T. A. Hoffmann (1816), retold by Alexandre Dumas in 1844.

A ballet A ballet tells a story with dance and music, but no talking. The orchestra plays all the music. Tchaikovsky also made a concert suite of eight pieces from it that is played without dancers.

Hearing it You will hear six pieces (movements). Each one matches a part of the story.

1 ACT I · THE PARTY

On Christmas Eve, Clara and her brother Fritz welcome guests. Her godfather Drosselmeyer, a toymaker, brings gifts, including a nutcracker doll shaped like a soldier. **(Movement 1, March)**

2 ACT I · MIDNIGHT

Fritz breaks the nutcracker, and Clara tucks it in. At midnight the Christmas tree grows tall and mice creep in. The Nutcracker leads the toy soldiers against the Mouse King. Clara throws her slipper, and the Nutcracker wins and turns into a prince.

3 ACT I · THE SNOWY FOREST

The Prince takes Clara through a forest where snowflakes dance. **(Movement 2, Waltz of the Snowflakes)**

4 ACT II · THE KINGDOM OF SWEETS

They arrive in a land of sweets ruled by the Sugar Plum Fairy. She welcomes them and orders dances to be shown for Clara. **(Movement 3, Trepak; Movement 4, Reed Flutes)**

5 ACT II · THE FLOWERS AND THE FAIRY

The flowers dance a waltz. The Sugar Plum Fairy and the Prince dance. **(Movement 5, Waltz of the Flowers; Movement 6, Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy)**

6 ACT II · GOODBYE

Clara says goodbye to her new friends. In many versions she wakes up at home, wondering if it was a dream.

Every company tells the story a little differently: names, scenes and endings change from one production to the next. This is one common version.

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DANCE OF THE SUGAR PLUM FAIRY

Act II · the Fairy dances · movement 6 of 6

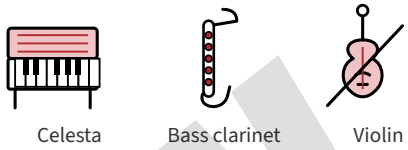
MOVEMENT 6

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

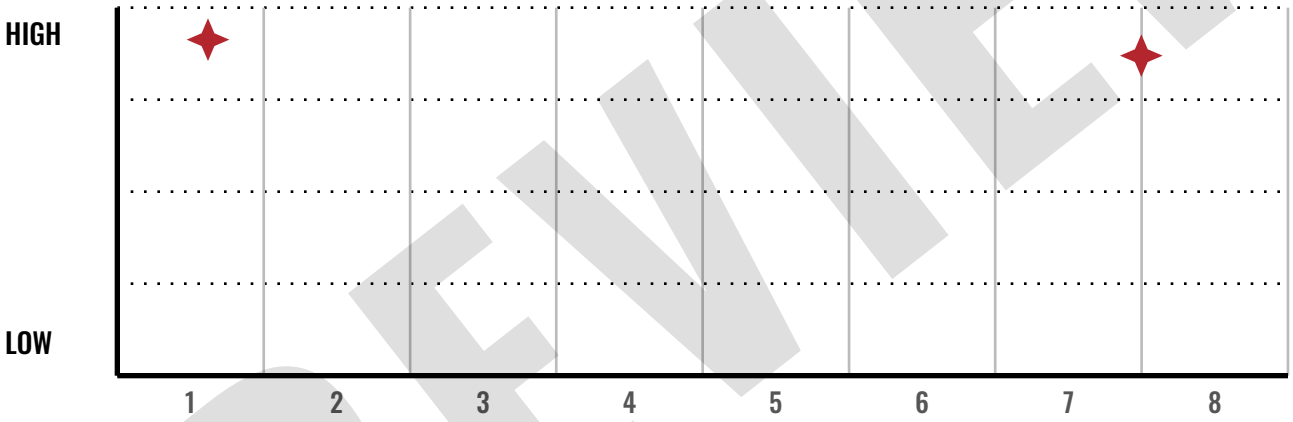
ABOUT THIS MUSIC

- The Sugar Plum Fairy rules the Kingdom of Sweets.
- Tchaikovsky heard a new instrument, the celesta, in Paris and wanted it for this dance.
- The celesta sparkles on top while a bass clarinet plays low and strings pluck.



Celesta Bass clarinet Violin

LISTENING MAP · Draw the tune as a line: up when the notes go higher, down when lower. Put an **S** by the sparkly sound and an **L** by a low sound.



Teacher: say "next" about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood MAGICAL | DAINTY | PEACEFUL | SLEEPY | THOUGHTFUL | COZY

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: "This music sounds like _____ because _____." **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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INSTRUMENT SPOTTING

Which instruments do you hear?

SPOT

Spotting chart

Name _____ Date _____

Listen to each movement again. Put an **X** under every instrument you can hear **clearly**. Many instruments play, so look for the ones that stand out.

MOVEMENT	VIOLIN	HARP	FLUTE	BASS CLARINET	TRUMPET	FRENCH HORN	CELESTA	CHILDREN'S VOICES
1 · March								
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes								
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)								
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes								
5 · Waltz of the Flowers								
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy								

WHICH WAS EASIEST TO HEAR? WHY?

INSTRUMENT FAMILIES

Write each instrument under its family.

Strings

Woodwinds

Brass

Percussion

Children's voices are not in an instrument family. Write them in the margin.

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ANSWER KEY

Answer key · story check, spotting chart and quiz

ANSWER KEY

Teacher copy

STORY CHECK (PAGE 4)

A · Story order, first to last	**Cards B F D A E C**
B · Who is who	Clara: **B** · Drosselmeyer: **D** · Mouse King: **A** · Sugar Plum Fairy: **C**

Part A: card letters in story order, so card B is 1 and card C is 6. Part C is open: accept any scene with one sentence.

INSTRUMENT SPOTTING (PAGE 13)

MOVEMENT	INSTRUMENTS THAT STAND OUT
1 · March	**Violin, Trumpet**
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes	**Violin, Children's voices**
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)	**Violin**
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes	**Flute**
5 · Waltz of the Flowers	**Violin, Harp, French horn**
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy	**Violin, Bass clarinet, Celesta**

Other instruments also play. Accept any you can truly hear, and listen once yourself first. Families: Strings = violin, harp · Woodwinds = flute, bass clarinet · Brass = trumpet, French horn · Percussion = celesta.

QUIZ (PAGE 14) · 16 POINTS

A · Clue number: movement	1: **5** · 2: **3** · 3: **1** · 4: **6** · 5: **2** · 6: **4**
B · Multiple choice	7: **B** · 8: **C** · 9: **A** · 10: **C** · 11: **B** · 12: **C**
C · True / false	13: **TRUE** · 14: **FALSE** · 15: **FALSE** · 16: **TRUE**

Scoring: 1 point each. 14–16 = excellent listener, 11–13 = good, 8–10 = keep listening, 0–7 = review the story and the toolkit.

MOVEMENT FACTS

MOVEMENT	METER IN THE MUSIC
1 · March	**4/4**
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes	**not asked**
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)	**2/4**
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes	**not asked**
5 · Waltz of the Flowers	**3/4**
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy	**not asked**

LISTENING MAPS (ANSWERS VARY)

Trepak: the needle moves toward FAST by the end. **Reed Flutes:** three flutes. **Sugar Plum Fairy:** the celesta is the sparkly high sound, the bass clarinet the low one. **Flowers:** the harp plays first; the tune begins after it. **March:** mark loud and soft as you hear them, and accept anything the class can support. **Snowflakes:** voices join the orchestra partway through. Maps and responses are about careful listening, so give credit for reasons.

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